SPORTS

BRO-FILE

JEREMY BLOOM

Mogul spanker and college-football standout Jeremy Bloom is poised to be the next dual-sport megastar.

As the Olympics wrap up in Italy, most of the athletes will be dragging their aching limbs to raging after-parties and rightfully letting loose like rock stars. Given the obscene popularity of skiing in Europe, one can only imagine how many bombshell groupies want a piece of Olympic wonderboy and part-time model Jeremy Bloom. So why will he be on a red-eye flight to Indianapolis? "That's easy," he explains. "To get there in time." Bloom, you see, is a former college-football star, and flying back early means having a shot at the NFL draft. Not even the party to end all parties can keep him overseas.

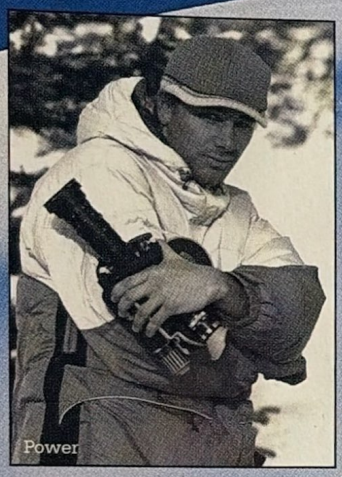
Wait—an Olympic skier in the National Football League? Believe it. As a wide receiver and punt-return specialist for the University of Colorado, Bloom was a highlight clip waiting to happen: He ran back a 75-yard kick on his first-ever play, snagged a school-record 94-yard touchdown pass and ranked fifth in the nation as a punt returner. The kid can ball. "I'm not worried about getting nailed," says Bloom, who is a slight 5-foot-11 and 185 pounds. "That's inevitable."

His opponents will have to catch him first—the multifaceted mountain man is just as explosive on the field as he is on the slopes. Bloom ran the 100-yard dash in 9.41 seconds during a made-for-TV SuperStars competition in 2003, bolting past Green Bay Packers speedster Ahman Green and into the NFL's consciousness. This winter, if all goes as planned, his transition from snow to turf will be seamless.

While we could discuss the eligibility battle Jeremy had with the NCAA and the fact that he was forced to shelve his cleats in order to train for the Olympics, we'd rather skip to the real question: Who gets more girls, skiers or football players? "Definitely football players," reports Bloom. "This is America, man! Football is king here." Sounds like this fella is making a wise career decision.

TUNE IN TO NBC FEBRUARY 15 FOR OLYMPIC FREESTYLE MOGUL SKIING ACTION!

Magnum!


Power

Remembered: Joel McCormick

Steele Spence's segment in the upcoming PBP flick *Ready, Fire, Aim* is something to see. For starters, it showcases Steele's abilities beyond his well-known rail savvy: hucking cliffs, hitting backcountry booters, and rallying competitions with equal aplomb. The segment itself is unique to any PBP film to date. Steele's own graphic-design work is laid over many of the shots, creating an edgy tension between Steele the skier and Steele the artist. Clips of Steele pacing back and forth explaining his muddled thought process intensify this tension.

Such a dramatic departure from PBP director Johnny Decesare's trademark style is the work of Joel McCormick, a 22-year-old cinematographer with an artistic eye and a close relationship with Steele. Having taken charge of several full-length ski movies and countless ski-related TV programs and commercials, Joel was no stranger to film. He dove into the arduous editing process with little more than a season's worth of footage and an AFI song to work with.

Joel's right arm went numb as he was getting started. Suspecting a pinched nerve, he decided to see a doctor. That afternoon Joel was diagnosed with a slow-growing tumor in his brain. When a second opinion confirmed the worst, surgery was scheduled for the following week.

Despite the gravity of his condition, Joel labored tirelessly with Steele on the segment. He filmed interviews, selected shots, edited artwork, and meshed these various elements together within the pulsing punk-rock soundtrack. Naturally, Johnny offered to take the project off his hands, but Joel wouldn't hear it. "Working on it makes me feel normal," he told Johnny.

Joel and Steele finished the segment the evening before the surgery. Steele overnighted the completed piece to Johnny as Joel was checking into the hospital the next day, and Poor Boyz received it the following morning. Barely ten minutes later, Johnny learned that Joel had died.

Rarely is the skiing community faced with anything more serious than bad snow conditions or nagging injuries. Death is something we seldom confront. "Joel was a shooting star," says Johnny. "He was a bright light in this world. If you were lucky enough to come into contact with Joel, he made you realize how great humanity is to have people like him."

At only 22, Joel had yet to fulfill his vast potential as an artist and documentarian of our sport. But the fact that creating Steele's segment helped him cope with the profound challenges he faced this past summer is a testament to his passion for skiing, film, and life. "Joel could do anything," says Steele. "He was the best thing that ever happened to my skiing career and my life. I would give anything to have him back."—**Jeff Foss**

Skier: Steele Spence
Location: Silverton, Colorado
Photo: Nate Abbott/PBP